personal future, and the unanswered questions about the conspirators and their intentions rankled on.

The day after I came out of jail, Muthunayagam visited me at home. I did not want to meet this man who, like the other bosses at ISRO, never spoke a word in support of their scientists who were falsely implicated and incarcerated. Muthunayagam had heard from someone that the IB officials had tried to make me name Muthunayagam and some other seniors, but I refused to play ball. Now he had come to show his gratitude.

Muthunayagam hugged me.

'You are great,' he said, crying.

I did not reply.

It was not out of any love for him. Naming Muthunayagam would be admitting to the lie that there was espionage in ISRO.

Once he was finished thanking me profusely, I said, 'If you are through with your expression of guilt, I would like to be left alone.'

Months later, when he came again to meet me, I locked myself in my room and told Meena to convey to him that I did not wish to meet him.

I led a life of a recluse, not stepping out of home. The few visitors were the inner circle of my relatives and friends. Businessman Kanwal Grover, the great friend of Indian space science who helped ISRO strike the Viking-Vikas deal, surprised me by knocking at my door a few days after I returned from jail.

'The moment I heard about it I knew someone was playing dirty,' said Grover.

'You didn't believe any of the spy tales, did you?' I was curious to know the perception of a globetrotter who would have only heard of the ISRO spy case.

'Not a word, Nambi,' he said. 'You know that I am no stranger to rockets though I am not a scientist. The whole set of allegations screamed conspiracy.'

My colleagues Mohana Prasad, Chandran and Narendranath were frequent visitors to my place. Mohana Prasad would analyse endlessly the motives of the conspirators who fabricated the spy case. Prasad, who lived